highway with this guy at about two in the morning. The guy noticed we were being followed, so we quickly dropped him off, then, further down the road, my mum and I were pulled over by the federal police. The policeman told her she might be described as an unfit mother, out with a child at 2 a.m. He told her she should stay out of politics. And she did after that. But I didn't.

School was a problem, though. Even Mr King, who taught me all sorts of things and was a masculine role model, couldn't make up for this lingering sense of waste that attached itself to school in my eyes. Perhaps I was just bred to hate the system and this was the system. I started wearing my hair long in spite of injunctions not to. Weirdly, I've always been ridiculed or judged on account of my hair, and it started early. My parents advised me to cut my blond mop, just to make it easier for me, but I wouldn't do it and I thrived on a kind of defiance. Before long I was refusing to tie my shoelaces in the normal way. I devised this elaborate system of wrapping the laces round the ankle and tying with a knot rather than a bow, and I began teaching this method to the other kids. Then I decided to dispense with shoes altogether and the teachers considered this to be a crime. I was often the new boy in school. So many times: the new boy. And I'd make my mark with these acts of defiance. We had no TV at home. There was hardly any money. We went to markets sometimes to scavenge for cabbages. I was happy with all this; it was part of the colour of life; it was part of doing things your own way. Only during one period of being a teenager was I ever status-conscious. I didn't want my mother dropping me outside school in an old crap car. But that was an aberration and it didn't last.

We had a feeling for animals. People had a sense of us, usually a disparaging sense of us, as hippies, but really we were just nature-lovers and natural non-conformists. At one time we kept chicks that gave us eggs, and three goats for milk. Our beloved dog Poss had to vie for attention with a veritable travelling menagerie comprising a donkey, a pony, a litter of mice – which my mother directed in candle-lit 'shows' – and at a cottage we once lived at on a pineapple farm our lives were taken over by possums. A large grey bird called a brolga took up residence, too. There was a sense that we were always seeking refuge from modern life. I was deeply invested, I now see, in trying to grow into a system of thinking about the relation between people and things. Years later I would study quantum mechanics and begin to see, but then I just grappled with the world on offer,